DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is the One Thing We Can Fully Know About God?

Daat Tevunot §29-34

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §29-34 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 29 September 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The first part in one paragraph

Given in the days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, this class opened with the summary printed in the English edition, which the Rabbi recommended to anyone who wants to know the purpose of life: - The student struggles with hashgahah, reward and punishment, Mashiah and tehiyat hametim, because world events often seem unjust. He is content to understand the general principles. - God is the ultimate good and wanted to give the greatest good. So He created us imperfect, with the task of perfecting ourselves and the world, so that the reward is earned, intrinsically ours, and not a source of shame. - Perfection is closeness to God; imperfection is whatever distances us from Him. - To make a world of imperfection, God held back His infinite essence.

A participant stressed that the key is the definition of perfection as closeness to God, not the world's definition. Once that is grasped, everything falls into place, and it is also the ultimate pleasure.

Born neither perfect nor flawed (§29-30)

The Neshamah asks to hear the further fundamentals. The Sekhel begins: we are created imperfect, with desires and tendencies that pull us away from perfection. Look at a baby, who wakes its parents at any hour: it is not perfect. But the Rabbi stressed that we are also not born only bad, as Christianity holds. We are born with both: a selfish, animal side, and a Neshamah with the potential to elevate ourselves completely.

That, he said, is what brit milah symbolises. The Torah speaks of circumcising the heart: "umaltem et orlat levavkhem" in Ekev, and "umal Hashem Elokekha et levavekha" in Nisavim. Brit milah is not complete with the cut alone. The halachah is "mal velo para kilo mal," if he cut but did not fold back, it is as if he did not circumcise. The periah, the pulling back, is restraint. At eight days old we tell the child what his life's work will be: you have impulses and you have huge potential, and the choice is yours.

A participant brought the Midrash of Turnus Rufus and Rabbi Akiva: God gives us wheat and we make bread; He left the world for us to finish. "Exactly," said the Rabbi. A perfect God held

Himself back to allow imperfection, so that we could perfect ourselves and acquire the good as our own. Asked whether imperfection is only because of the sin of Adam and Havah, he said it is aggravated by that, but exists even without it: Adam too had a restraint to keep, not eating from the tree.

A great sea that needs patience (§30-31)

How can imperfect beings perfect themselves? The Sekhel says the answer will come only much later. "We are now entering a great sea," and several fundamentals must be laid down first. The Rabbi underlined the line about patience: no one becomes wise overnight; wisdom comes only with patience, learning more and more. Some of what follows may not seem directly connected, but together the pieces will form the whole picture. The Neshamah replies: speak, and I am listening with all possible patience and calm.

Principle one: only a drop (§32-33)

God wants to give good, and the good is closeness to Him and recognition of Him. The better you are, the more good you receive. But He will never give everything. The Rabbi compared it to people: if you could fully enter another person's mind, you would be that person. Even the closest friends or spouses cannot. That is why there are heart transplants but no brain transplants: with a new brain, it is no longer you.

So whatever we attain will be only a drop from the sea of God's perfection, though that drop will be the greatest pleasure, and how big it is depends on us. The Ramhal cites Iyov on this: who can claim to know God's ways? The Neshamah agrees that this is clear to any wise person.

Principle two: His oneness (§34)

Before reading inside, the Rabbi explained where the Ramhal is going, tying it to the Thirteen Attributes said repeatedly in this season. When we say God is Rahum, Hanun, Erekh Apayim, what do we really understand? If we grasp only a drop of God, we grasp only a drop of His mercy. The Rambam says these attributes can be understood only in the negative: He is not "not merciful."

A participant objected that even the negative is unclear, since God's mercy may look like the opposite to us. The Rabbi agreed that we do not always recognise it, but said we understand the concept: a father who strikes his child out of love is acting in mercy, even if the child does not see it.

There is only one thing we can grasp fully: that God is one. Oneness is a negation, and negation we can do completely. To understand mercy positively you would have to reach its end. To understand that He is one, you only need to negate everything else.

Reading inside: when we look at all of God's great deeds since creating man, and all He promised through the prophets, what we see clearly is "osem yihudo," the power of His unity. His other perfections are beyond us. We know God is wise, but we cannot say what that means in totality. The Rabbi cited the Zohar's "Patah Eliyahu," which describes God as wise but not with a wisdom we can know.

Do not investigate, but do imitate

Because the other attributes cannot be grasped, we are told not to probe them: if your mind runs after them, return. A participant asked whether that contradicts the duty to walk in His ways, "as He is merciful, so you be merciful." The Rabbi said the warning is against philosophical investigation, not against talking about God or living by His attributes. When saying the Thirteen Attributes we take them at face value: Hashem is Rahum, so I should be Rahum.

Oneness is the opposite. Because we can understand it fully, we are obligated to, and to fix it in our hearts without doubt, as Moshe commands: "veyadata hayom vahashevota el levavekha." Everything that happens in the universe serves to reveal God's unity: "Reu attah ki ani ani hu," see now that I, I am He, at the end of Haazinu, after all the upheavals of history. Yeshayahu says the same: so that you know that I am He, before Me no god was formed and after Me there will be none. The Rabbi linked this to the Selihot and to the season: the purpose of Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur is that everyone comes round to this.

Summary

- The book's first part: God created us imperfect so that we earn the good, closeness to Him, through our own effort.
- We are born neither wholly good nor wholly bad; brit milah, with its periah, symbolises the lifelong task of restraint and growth.
- The answers ahead require patience: wisdom does not come overnight.
- Principle one: whatever we attain of God is only a drop from His sea.
- Principle two: His unity is the one thing we can know fully, because it is a negation, and so we are obligated to know it and bring it into the heart.

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